unless state governments went out of their way, developed special mechanisms and ensured security.

The ball was in the courts of the states and UTs to ensure that temporary accommodation facilities were provided and that access to food, water, toilets and drinking water was granted to those from our most marginalized sections. A disturbing outcome of a study published by the Tata Institute of Social Sciences in Hyderabad showed that out of a sample size of 10,672 migrant workers surveyed between 16 April and 4 May, nearly 97 per cent did not have ration cards in the destination city and thus, would not be guaranteed availability of food and ration benefits announced by the Centre.[4] However, later in June, the prime minister announced the 'One Nation One Ration Card' scheme with interstate portability of the cards and thus opened up access to free food grains from any food provision service store of choice all over the country.[5]

In a disconcerting study conducted by India Migration Now and Dvara Research, between 5 and 11 April 2020, it was found that 47 per cent of the migrant responders were not aware of the relief schemes announced by the government.[6] This translated to chaos amongst this vulnerable population and a feeling of helplessness. In distress, where society at large was relying on the government for their safety and welfare, it was natural for the short-term migrant community to feel orphaned owing to the unawareness of welfare schemes.

While this was in the truest sense a large-scale humanitarian crisis and was initially driven by behavioural psychology, it began to become an issue which the opposition parties could exploit in order to launch an attack at the government. While making reverse migration a subject in their anti-government campaign was malicious enough, it was their indulgence in rumour-mongering and misinformation campaign which egged more migrants to come out on the roads. For over a week when this crisis engulfed the country, the leading opposition party and its top leaders reposted viral videos from Delhi's and Mumbai's transport hubs, forcing those migrants who had made the choice to stay put to reconsider their decision on account of so many deciding to mobilize.

On 28 March, Rahul Gandhi tweeted a viral video showcasing a large crowd gathered at a bus stop in New Delhi with a by-line, 'Out of work & facing an uncertain future, millions of our brothers & sisters across India are struggling to find their way back home. It's shameful that we've